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Balance (including structure)

Length

Intensity / Concentration (two different things)

Complexity

Commercial position especially within its own region / peer group

Texture

Typicity / Terroir

Oak

Ability to age and improve (includes maturity)

Development in the glass

Value judgement ie. Your overall assessment of whether it's a poor / good / excellent example of it's category

QUALITY - 5 levels

Mass market / Entry Level
Mid Market - lower / upper
Premium - lower / upper
Upper Premium
Super premium

1	Mass Market	£4.99
2	Entry Level	5.99
3	Lower Mid Market	6-7
4	Well made Mid Market	7-8
5	Upper Mid Market	8-10
6	Lower Premium Market	9-12
7	Well made Premium Market	10-15
8	Upper Premium Market	15-20
9	Super Premium	20-50
10	First Growth - Grand Cru - Super Cuvée - Icon - Fine Wine	50+

Comment on the quality of the wine in the context of its region of production.

The heart of questions like this is simple: is this

Pauillac/Margaux/Pomerol/Pessac a Poor/Sound/Good/Outstanding example of its type, and why.

BALANCE

Often related to drinkability or elegance not necessarily A balanced with B

Adverbs to replace “good” when talking about balance

Reasonably balanced

Satisfyingly balanced

LENGTH (after Schuster)

Look for length in 4 places

On the nose, does it repay your attention, does it reward lingering over

In the mouth - how long does the wine hold your attention, does it have inner dynamism

Finish - how far does it reach back down the throat

Persistence, how long does the flavour linger

Tenacity of flavour

INTENSITY / CONCENTRATION

Not the same thing, learn to distinguish between the two

A Mosel Riesling at 9% can be intense

Concentration is like in cooking, something that is boiled down, thick, concentrated. Does not necessarily mean it is also intense!

COMPLEXITY

Multi layered

One dimensional

Adequate complexity

Lacks complexity

If you find yourself writing more than four or five descriptors for the nose and / or palate then the wine probably has some complexity.

Complexity = you know it when you see it

COMMERCIAL POSITION

Increasingly in the MW exam “quality” is not a stand alone concept, you are asking for your judgement of quality as relative to it’s own region / peer group or appellation quality system

TEXTURE

An important, but often overlooked, element, especially at the higher end of quality

TYPICITY / TERROIR

If a wine is a clear example of a regional style / variety then it is showing an aspect of quality. Similarly, a lack of place or identity can indicate lower quality.

OAK

We know when visiting wineries that the quality of the oak and its handling can often set apart a good producer from a great one - you need to be able to talk about this in the context of quality and wines where oak is part of the style.

ABILITY TO AGE AND IMPROVE

AGE

Colour will lighten / darken

Bouquet will sweeten

Structure will soften

Tannins will resolve

MATURITY

Is it drinking now? Yes / No - why? 2 elements

If not, when

And for how long - why? 2 elements

DEVELOPMENT IN THE GLASS

Not always easy to see in a tasting exam, but often the deciding factor between a pair of classics from the same region / producer. Often the “lower” quality wine will show better at first, be more open, fruit forward and attractive - which can be mistaken for higher quality. The “higher” quality wine may be more backward, due to having more structure or being made to be more age worthy. Over time and with air it will open up and show its true colours. This is why it's best never to do the classic flight first, but also don't leave it to last as you often need to write more.

VALUE JUDGEMENT

This is linked to the Commercial Position point above. Where there are a large number of points for a quality answer, the examiners want to see more than just a list of tasting notes, they want to know your *opinion*, and that means judging the quality relative to the context of region and / or variety.